

Hi, everybody! It's been a while.

I apologize if this story seems a bit like some lame paperback you'd buy at Walgreens, but the people down at MassFiction (see that other PDF—Sampil3) gave me that covert sort of briefcase and I think the gun too, and I've already started the story this way, so I figure, even if it's trite and perhaps feeds into the stereotype of a 16-year-old guy (though my birthday is in a week!), I might as well keep on going with it. After all, it needs an ending. Which I'll give it someday, I guess. Phases into *italic* halfway through, to show you *italic*, as you no doubt have figured out already.

I reviewed my situation. A month ago I had been "rightsized". At first I stayed afloat on my severance package, just waiting to find another job. Each day I scoured the bulletin boards at Kroger for anything that might offer even a little bit of money for me to get back on my feet with, but nobody I called gave me a call back. Maybe my voice sounded somehow "unreliable" on the phone, or maybe the season was just particularly ripe with job applicants, and I was too late to snag any opportunities. Whatever the case, about two weeks later I found myself sitting on my couch with stubble on my face and a large empty spot in my stomach. I was able to afford the occasional hot meal, but mostly I learned that scrounging around in the garbage cans isn't all that bad, and you can keep your dignity if nobody sees you doing it. I got sick once or twice, but it was nothing very serious. I still swept the bulletin boards each day.

One day, I found a notice that was intriguing in its vagueness. It was an aloof shade of green, sort of like money, and it just said, in austere letters, "Good Pay for Various Jobs." There followed a phone number. I called it up. The guy who answered asked me a little about myself, and then I was instructed to meet a man at 6:30 the next day at a certain address, which I discovered was a burned-out building with boarded windows on the outskirts of town. I was just about to concede that I had been had, and laugh dryly, when an old gray-haired and sharp-dressed man stepped out of a car and greeted me cordially. I got the feeling that he was supposed to be cordial, but could also be severe if he needed to.

No cars went by on the street as he gradually told me what the job I had applied for was going to be. He never used the words "kill" or "people". Instead he said things like "clean out" and "evil elements". I was of course not so pliable in my perceptions as not to realize what was going on. I knew he wanted me to work as a hit man, and there wasn't even a question about it: it wasn't going to happen. I listened politely until I realized this, then listened incredulously for a few moments, and, when the man put in a strategically placed pause, I told him face-on, "Not a chance in hell," and turned around and walked to my car. He

cordially called out my name, but I just opened the door. Then he called my name with more force. I turned around and discovered he had a gun pointed at me.

I was right that he could be severe if he needed to. I felt a chill as though I had stepped into a walk-in freezer whenever I caught a glimpse of the cold impartiality etched in his old face, so I kept only an oblique eye contact. He told me that from what I said to the man on the phone, they knew I had no connections to anyone, I was out of a job, and nobody would miss me very long or look very hard for me if I simply vanished. I realized with a shudder of reality that this was true. Then he told me that there was no way to opt out of the game—after he dropped the pretense he always referred to it as "the game", for short—because their agents could monitor me in ways I wouldn't even be able to think of until it was too late. I wondered who "they" were, but he never told me and I never worked up enough nerve to ask. I also wondered, If their agents were so all-powerful, why didn't they just kill the people they needed dead? I figured that even if I asked him that, there was some secret stratagem behind it and he would never tell me why. As the conversation went on, it got darker outside and I got more and more disconcerted. It was only about ten minutes before I had backed up against my car and was constantly darting my eyes to the tops of distant buildings to look for a soulless man in black clothes about to snipe me between the eyes. As the old man went on about different methods of torture, which he described in detail that would make the most stalwart horror movie director lapse into a panic, I became a shaking wreck. Eventually I gave in and just melted to the asphalt. Maybe I was hoping I would evaporate. It didn't happen. Instead he told me the place where I was going to get my assignment. At that point I was curled up with my hands to my ears, trying to make it stop. I knew as fact that if he told me anything else at all my brain would collapse in on itself and I would simply cease to be. For a moment I thought that didn't sound too bad. He bent down and stuffed a piece of paper in my hand so I wouldn't forget. Then he left. I lay there on the ground and tried to wake up. I couldn't, because I wasn't asleep and it wasn't a nightmare. Eventually I got to my knees and entered the car. I looked behind me the whole way home.

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Amazingly, he makes a major life-change! For example: I'll require the system to have two sizes.